

# Act 1, Scene 1

**Location: 'Open country', a deserted forest or hill in Scotland**

## Summary

The three witches meet on a stormy night out in the open country to discuss when they should meet with Macbeth.

## Analysis

The opening scene of Macbeth is very short but it introduces us to three of the most important and influential characters of the play – the three witches. The witches' physical presence in the play is very small but they remain a constant and influential presence throughout. This first short scene establishes the witches' connection to Macbeth, the subject of the play, who they plan to meet. It makes the audience curious to discover who he is and also what is 'the hurlyburly' (I, i, 3) that the witches have been discussing. With this device, Shakespeare creates dramatic irony, in that he equips the audience with knowledge that Macbeth does not have and will never have throughout the action of the play, namely that the witches have an evil plan for him.

## Setting

The scene is set in 'the open country' in a storm and provides a prime example of pathetic fallacy, the device in which writers use the weather to reflect the mood or emotion of the scene. For example: When shall we three meet again, In thunder, lightning or in rain? (I, i, 1–2) This dark and murky weather alerts the audience to the fact that the story will be dark and supernatural.

## Stage directions

Thunder is noted in the stage directions in this and all of the scenes featuring the witches, and the witches themselves often refer to the bad weather conditions.

## Language and style

The witches always appear as a group and are never differentiated between. Their speech mirrors this. Each witch speaks a line, which is continued by the next witch to create a continuous rhyme. In addition, they sometimes speak in unison as if they know what the others are thinking. This enhances their paranormal quality. The witches' language is a type of rhythmic incantation and it appears in stark contrast to the mannered speech of noblemen that is adopted by most of the other characters in the play. It is also full of riddles and paradoxes, such as '... when the battle's lost and won' (I, i, 4), that leave the audience in no doubt that they are watching evil and subnormal creatures with their own bizarre values and morals. The witches refer to their two familiars, Graymalkin and Paddock, and appear to answer their calls. This, in itself, is enough to secure the audience's impression of them as witches.

## Debate Prompts

1. Why do you think Shakespeare chose to open the play with the witches, rather than Macbeth?
2. What is the effect of this first scene? What impressions does it make on you, the audience?

# Act 1, Scene 2 & Scene 3

3. What is the effect of the way the witches speak?

## Act 1, Scene 2

### Location: A soldier's camp near Forres

#### Summary

The audience is introduced to King Duncan and his three sons. King Duncan hears from several soldiers of Macbeth's bravery in battle and decides to make Macbeth Thane of Cawdor.

#### Analysis

As the scene opens, King Duncan and his sons meet a wounded officer and ask him for news of the battle. The officer tells them that Macbeth fought a close battle with Macdonald and the rebellious Scottish and Irish forces that he led, but that Macbeth was victorious. Macbeth then killed Macdonald. The audience learns that Macbeth is related to King Duncan: 'O valiant cousin! Worthy gentleman!' (I, ii, 24). This also shows that, at this point in the play, Macbeth is held in high regard by Duncan. The officer explains that the army immediately faced a new threat from the Norwegian king, who launched a fresh attack. Macbeth and his fellow captain Banquo were not afraid and they fought wholeheartedly and violently to defeat their enemy. The officer is too weak from his wounds to finish his story and so Duncan sends him away to be attended to by doctors. Angus and Ross enter the stage and they are able to give King Duncan the news that he has been waiting for. They have come from the battle and inform Duncan that Macbeth has led his army to victory. The Norwegian king has been fined and forced to retreat. They also mention that the Thane of Cawdor has betrayed Duncan by fighting on the Norwegian side.

#### Characterisation

In this scene, Macbeth is portrayed as a brave and loyal soldier. Duncan decides that the Thane of Cawdor should be killed and that his title should be conferred upon Macbeth as a reward for his courage and his loyalty: 'What he [the Thane of Cawdor] hath lost, noble Macbeth hath won' (I, ii, 67). This is an important quotation because the audience will later realise that when Macbeth becomes the Thane of Cawdor, he is as disloyal as his predecessor and pays for it with his life. The audience is reminded of how Macbeth has changed throughout the action of the play and how treachery cannot go unpunished.

#### Context

This scene provides the audience with an introduction to the social context of the play. This is a society that is constantly at threat from external forces, at a time when wars were fought on bloody battlefields. Men gained wealth, power and status from their prowess in battle and paid with their life for their misdemeanours. The audience also learns that the play is set in Scotland, which was important at the time it was written because King James I had just come to the throne, having previously reigned as King James VI of Scotland. Shakespeare portrays Scottish people as brave, loyal and nationalistic. He also includes characters from Scottish history, including Banquo.

#### Debate Prompt

Read this scene again. Find some quotations that show Macbeth in a good light at this point in the play. Why do you think Shakespeare has chosen to portray Macbeth as a brave and loyal soldier at the start of the play?

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## Act 1, Scene 3

### Location: A heath near Forres

#### Summary

Macbeth and his friend, Banquo, meet the three witches on the heath as they return from battle. The witches make three predictions for each of them and Macbeth begins to wonder what the future might hold for him.

#### Analysis

Once again, the three witches enter the stage to the sounds of thunder. They boast of their evil powers and discuss their activities since the last meeting. The third witch alludes to the limits of their power: 'Though his bark cannot be lost, / Yet it shall be tempest-tossed' (I, iii, 24–25). She is talking about a sailor that she wishes to upset. She means that while she cannot make the boat disappear, she can make his journey very unpleasant. Remembering the limits of the witches' power is important as the play progresses. A drum roll announces the approach of Macbeth and so the witches recite another incantation to prepare their spell. Macbeth speaks his first line of the play: 'So foul and fair a day I have not seen' (I, iii, 38). This is the first indication that the witches have some kind of power over Macbeth. Even at this early stage in the play, he is unknowingly echoing their words. It is Banquo who first notices the witches and he is clearly suspicious of them. He notes that they 'look not like th' inhabitants o' th' Earth' (I, iii, 41) and describes them using various unflattering adjectives. He questions whether they are alive and whether they understand what he is saying. Macbeth instructs them to speak and they proceed to hail him as Thane of Glamis, Thane of Cawdor and king 'hereafter'. Banquo notices that Macbeth has gone quiet and appears to be lost in thought. He believes that Macbeth is afraid of the witches and wonders why he would be afraid of such nice predictions. He challenges the witches to make a prediction about his future and the response is as follows: Lesser than Macbeth and greater. Not so happy, yet much happier. Thou shall get kings, though thou be none. (I, iii, 65–67) This prediction seems to bring Macbeth back to reality and he demands more information. He has inherited his title as Thane of Glamis, but how can he become the Thane of Cawdor or king? At this stage, Macbeth does not know that the Thane of Cawdor has betrayed Duncan. Macbeth addresses the witches in a way which suggests that he has some power over them and continues to do so throughout the play. However, even in this first instance, they ignore his demands and disappear. Banquo and Macbeth confirm what they have been told and wonder whether they have been hallucinating, before hearing the approach of Ross and Angus. Ross and Angus bring the news that Macbeth will become Thane of Cawdor, thus confirming the witches' first prophecy. Macbeth questions how this is possible, while Banquo is wondering how the witches knew this. With confirmation of the news, Macbeth appears to have been won over by the witches: [Aside] Glamis, and Thane of Cawdor! The greatest is behind. Thanks for your pains. [Aside to BANQUO] Do you not hope your children shall be kings, When those that gave the thane of Cawdor to me Promised no less to them? (I, iii, 116–120)

#### Characterisation

We learn a lot about Macbeth and Banquo's personalities from this encounter with the witches. As soon as Macbeth finds out that the witches' first prediction for him (that he will be made Thane of Cawdor) has come true, he seems to unquestioningly believe the witches' words, forgetting that there was ever any reason to doubt them. However, Banquo continues to be wise and suspicious. He notes that evil beings often tell us half-truths that lead to our destruction. He leaves the stage to talk with Ross and Angus, leaving Macbeth to contemplate how he can make the next prediction happen. He already has evil thoughts, mentioning 'murder' in this soliloquy. Banquo notes Macbeth's strange behaviour and suggests that it is because of his shock at receiving the new title. Before exiting the stage, Macbeth and Banquo agree to think about what they have experienced and to meet later to discuss it.

#### Debate Prompts

# Debate Prompt 4

4. Why do you think Macbeth is so interested in Banquo's prophecy? Are there any ways in which Banquo's prophecies could later affect Macbeth?

# Act 1, Scenes 4–7

5. Why do you think Shakespeare chose to inform the audience of Macbeth's reward before telling Macbeth himself?

*Macbeth and Banquo meeting the witches on the heath by Théodore Chassériau*

## Act 1, Scene 4

### Location: Duncan's palace at Forres

#### Summary

King Duncan welcomes Macbeth and Banquo back from battle and makes Macbeth Thane of Cawdor.

#### Analysis

A trumpet announces the arrival of King Duncan and his sons and they discuss the fate of the Thane of Cawdor. Duncan remarks that it is difficult to judge men's thoughts by their appearance and expression: 'There's no art / To find the mind's construction in the face' (I, iv, 11–12). He goes on to say that the Thane of Cawdor was 'a gentleman on whom I built / An absolute trust' (I, iv, 13–14). The audience will come to wonder whether Duncan is a bad judge of character, or whether none of his thanes are worthy of trust. Macbeth enters with Banquo, Angus and Ross. Duncan takes the opportunity to thank Macbeth for his efforts and also notes that Banquo deserves 'no less than Macbeth'. Duncan names Macbeth as Thane of Cawdor and Malcolm as the Prince of Cumberland, the heir to the throne. Macbeth realises that Malcolm is now an obstacle in his quest to become king and his words reveal his growing ambition: The prince of Cumberland! That is a step On which I must fall down, or else o'erleap, For in my way it lies. (I, iv, 49–51) Duncan invites himself to Macbeth's castle to celebrate these appointments and so Macbeth goes ahead to inform his wife. Duncan and Banquo continue to discuss Macbeth's merits before they leave the stage, following Macbeth to his castle in Inverness.

#### Debate Prompt

Do you think that the witches are to blame for Macbeth's ambition to become king, or is Macbeth responsible for his own thoughts and actions?

## Act 1, Scene 5

### Location: Macbeth's castle at Inverness

#### Summary

Macbeth is reunited with his wife, Lady Macbeth, at their castle. Lady Macbeth has heard about the witches' predictions from a letter Macbeth has written her, and she is now determined to kill King Duncan. She tells Macbeth of her intentions and says that she will take care of everything herself.

#### Analysis

Lady Macbeth appears on stage for the first time reading a letter from Macbeth. She reads about the witches' prophecies and of Macbeth's latest title.

#### Characterisation

Lady Macbeth notes that Macbeth could become king but she is worried that while he is ambitious, he lacks the mean streak required to fulfil his dreams: Glamis thou art, and Cawdor; and shalt be What thou art promised. Yet do I fear thy nature; It is too full o' th' milk of human kindness To catch the nearest way: thou wouldst be great, Art not without ambition, but without The illness should attend it. (I, v, 14–20) Lady Macbeth believes that he wants to achieve greatness only through noble means and plans to persuade him otherwise. Her words tell us that Macbeth has an honourable side and some desire to be a good man. They also tell us that Lady Macbeth is more ruthless than her husband. She is confident that she will be able to manipulate him to do as she wishes. A servant interrupts Lady Macbeth to tell her that the king is coming to the castle and that Macbeth is on his way too. Lady Macbeth is very happy with this arrangement and begins a soliloquy that makes clear her intention to kill Duncan. She notes the need to 'unsex' (I, v, 40) herself. By this, she means that she wants to be more like a man and less like a woman – she wants to be strong, ruthless and cruel so that she can commit murder. Lady Macbeth is, like the witches, not a typical woman. Macbeth arrives and is immediately told of the murderous plan: 'Look like th' innocent flower, / But be the serpent under 't' (I, v, 64–65). Here, she is instructing Macbeth to look innocent and concerned about Duncan's fate, even though he is responsible. This continues the theme of deceptive appearances – deception and trickery come naturally to Lady Macbeth. Macbeth does not argue with her or question her instructions. They plan to discuss the matter further but Lady Macbeth informs him that she will take care of everything, as long as he remains outwardly happy and peaceful to their guests. Macbeth's compliance suggests that his wife is the more powerful character in this marriage.

#### Debate Prompt

Is Lady Macbeth an entirely evil character? Are there any ways in which she could be described as strong and brave?

## Act 1, Scene 6

### Location: In the grounds of Macbeth's castle at Inverness

#### Summary

King Duncan and his men arrive at Macbeth's castle and are welcomed by Lady Macbeth.

#### Analysis

#### Setting

King Duncan arrives at the castle accompanied by his sons, Banquo, Macduff, Ross and Angus. They discuss how nice Macbeth's castle is and how they have always liked it. Banquo observes that the castle is always surrounded by birds and suggests that this is because they like to be in clean air, with pleasant surroundings: 'Where they most breed and haunt, I have observed, / The air is delicate' (I, vi, 9–10). This comes in stark contrast to the 'filthy air' (I, i, 12) that is continually referred to by the witches. Lady Macbeth enters and Duncan thanks her for her hospitality and apologises for the inconvenience of their arrival. She remarks that her hospitality is due to her gratitude for Macbeth's new wealth and status. She tells them that they should make themselves at home and enjoy her castle. The men wonder where Macbeth is and ask to be taken to him.

#### Theme – appearance and reality

Duncan's naivety and Lady Macbeth's skilfulness at playing the welcoming hostess are underlined in this scene, as is the theme of the gulf of difference between appearances and reality. It is worth remembering that Lady Macbeth's success in playing the hostess is indicative of her awareness of what is good and right. She knows the right things to say to Duncan because she knows that they owe a lot to his generosity, and yet she is still intent on her plot to kill him. Her real feelings are very different indeed from the feelings that she shows towards her guests. Lady Macbeth appears to have no problems with her conscience at this point in the play.

#### Context

In both this scene and Scene 7, we are invited to consider gender roles and appropriate relationships between man and wife. The different interpretations of these interactions are particularly useful for us when considering the role of women in society at different times in history. Lady Macbeth's behaviour towards King Duncan is also telling of what the socially acceptable behaviour for women was at the time the play was written. She is an interesting character because she knows how she is meant to behave and does her best to pretend to, but underneath she is far from conventional.

#### Debate Prompt

What are the dramatic effects of these differences between appearance and reality? What effect do they have on the audience?

## Act 1, Scene 7

### Location: Macbeth's castle at Inverness

#### Summary

Macbeth has doubts about the plan to murder King Duncan and expresses these to his wife. Lady Macbeth mocks and belittles him, suggesting that he is not a real man unless he goes through with the plan as agreed. In the end, Macbeth agrees to do as his wife says, and carry out the plot to murder the king.

#### Analysis

Macbeth enters the stage alone and considers his wife's suggestions. He admits that he would kill Duncan if he could be sure that he would not be punished for it, but he knows that this is not the case. Macbeth notes that Duncan trusts him not only as a subject but also as a member of his family. In addition, Duncan is his guest and so Macbeth should be protecting him from murder, not plotting to murder him himself. Macbeth realises that Duncan is a noble and honourable king, who would be sorely missed by his subjects. Macbeth realises that only his ambition is spurring him to kill Duncan: 'I have no spur / To prick the sides of my intent, but only / Vaulting ambition, which o'erleaps itself / And falls on th' other' (I, vii, 25–28). He means that his senses tell him it is the wrong thing to do and he knows that excessive ambition can lead to downfall. Lady Macbeth enters and tells Macbeth that the king is wondering where he is. Macbeth immediately explains to her that he cannot go on with the plan. She chastises him for his cowardice. Macbeth argues that he can only do what it is proper to do to become king: 'I dare do all that may become a man; / Who dares do more is none' (I, vii, 46–47). At this point, he suggests that it is unmanly to become king using underhand tactics. Lady Macbeth argues that he was in fact a man when he was willing to do whatever was required to become king, not doing so would make him a coward. She suggests that she would never go back on such a plan. Lady Macbeth explains to Macbeth how they could kill Duncan and get away with it. They plot to frame some servants and, with a seemingly foolproof plan in place, Macbeth agrees to do it: I am settled, and bend up Each corporal agent to this terrible feat. Away, and mock the time with fairest show. False face must hide what the false heart doth know. (I, vii, 80–83)

#### Debate Prompts

# Debate Prompt 6

6. What is the dramatic effect of Macbeth's battle with his conscience?



# Act 2, Scenes 1 & 2

7. Why do you think Macbeth decides to go through with it? Do you think he is trying to please his wife, or is he following his own ambition?

## Act 2, Scene 1

### Location: Macbeth's castle at Inverness

#### Summary

Banquo and his son, Fleance, are awake late at night when they encounter Macbeth walking through the castle. They talk briefly about the three witches before Macbeth prepares himself for the gruesome task that he has agreed to carry out – the murder of the king.

#### Analysis

Banquo arrives on stage with Fleance. He is tired and cannot sleep. He is interrupted and startled by Macbeth and a servant. Banquo tells Macbeth that the king is already sleeping but has sent him to give a diamond to Lady Macbeth to thank her for her hospitality. Banquo mentions the witches, who have interrupted his dreams. Macbeth lies to Banquo by telling him that he no longer thinks of the witches. He then contradicts himself by saying that Banquo should stick close to him in order to reap rewards when he is the king. Banquo appears to have some inkling of Macbeth's bad intention. He says: So I lose none In seeking to augment it, but still keep My bosom franchised and allegiance clear, I shall be counselled. (II, i, 26–29) He means that he will stay loyal to Macbeth, as long as he is behaving honestly and morally. Banquo and Fleance exit and Macbeth sends his servant to bed. Macbeth is left alone to give his famous dagger soliloquy: 'Is this a dagger which I see before me...' (II, i, 34). In this speech, he hallucinates and sees a bloody knife in front of him, leading him to Duncan's bedroom. He considers whether he is hallucinating because of what he is about to do and repeatedly wonders why he can see the dagger but cannot touch it. He continually asks whether his eyes are playing tricks on him. This speech shows Macbeth's turmoil about what he is about to do. The audience is left to wonder whether Macbeth is seeing things because of the pressure he is under or whether perhaps the witches are responsible for the vision, as they attempt to encourage Macbeth to commit the bloody deed.

#### Language and style

The lines 53–57 convey vividly Macbeth's personification of murder as a withered creature creeping towards his victim: ... withered murder, Alarumed by his sentinel, the wolf, Whose howl's his watch, thus with his stealthy pace, With Tarquin's ravishing strides, towards his design Moves like a ghost. (II, i, 53–57) This metaphor may in turn be linked with the role of the witches throughout the play. He forces himself to hurry because the more he talks, the more worried he becomes: 'Words to the heat of deeds too cold breath gives' (II, i, 62). Macbeth's language shows his increasing anxiety and fear. A bell rings and Macbeth takes this as his invitation to act. Duncan's fate is sealed with one simple sentence: 'I go and it is done, the bell invites me' (II, i, 63). The bell informs Macbeth that the servants are now asleep. He takes it as the moment to make his final decision.

## Act 2, Scene 2

### Location: Macbeth's castle at Inverness

#### Summary

Macbeth has murdered King Duncan and is already beginning to feel guilty and afraid. Lady Macbeth tells him to stop being a coward and to wash the blood from his hands while she returns the daggers to the king's room.

#### Analysis

Lady Macbeth enters the stage and remarks: 'That which hath made them drunk hath made me bold' (II, ii, 1). She is referring to the alcohol that she has given to Duncan's servants to make them fall asleep. Lady Macbeth has drunk a little of it to make her brave and ready for the night ahead. She seems excited about Duncan's murder and entertained by the irony of the guards, who are drugged to such an extent that it is impossible to tell whether they are living or dead. She hears a noise from offstage and worries that her husband has been interrupted in his task. She had wanted to murder Duncan herself. Macbeth enters and announces: 'I have done the deed' (II, ii, 15) before asking 'Didst thou hear a noise?' (II, ii, 15). He is already paranoid about what he has done, wondering who is sleeping in the chambers next to Duncan's. Macbeth tells Lady Macbeth that the servants woke up while he was in the room, but muttered their prayers and went back to sleep. Macbeth struggled to say 'Amen' and then began to hear voices: ... it cried 'Sleep no more!' to all the house. 'Glamis hath murdered sleep, and therefore Cawdor Shall sleep no more. Macbeth shall sleep no more.' (II, ii, 40–42) This threat will haunt Macbeth throughout the rest of the play.

#### Characterisation

Macbeth is clearly traumatised by what he has just done, suggesting that he is keenly aware of the horrific nature of his actions. Lady Macbeth takes control of the situation with sensible and practical instructions. She tells him to wash his hands and chastises him for bringing the daggers back to his chamber with him. Lady Macbeth seems to be much calmer, braver and more ruthless than Macbeth at this point in the play.

#### Theme – guilt

Macbeth refuses to return to Duncan's chamber because he cannot bring himself to look again upon the crime he has committed, showing that he feels a measure of guilt. Lady Macbeth angrily agrees to take the daggers back to the scene of the crime. She exits the stage, while a knocking is heard. Macbeth is terrified of the noise and disgusted by the blood on his hands. He asks, 'Will all great Neptune's ocean wash this blood / Clean from my hand?' (II, ii, 59–60) and decides that it will not. He means that he will never be able to wash away the guilt of Duncan's murder and this metaphor of blood-stained hands will continue throughout the play. Lady Macbeth returns and calls him cowardly for his feelings – however, later in the play she is the character who becomes deranged by her actions and unable to live with them, while Macbeth hardens himself to his feelings of guilt. Lady Macbeth confesses that she would have killed Duncan herself but was unable to because he reminded her of her father – perhaps this is a rare acknowledgement of some degree of a guilty conscience in Lady Macbeth.

#### Debate Prompt

Do you think Lady Macbeth is as calm as she would like the audience and Macbeth to believe? What makes you think she is or is not?

# Act 2, Scenes 3 & 4

## Act 2, Scene 3

### Location: Macbeth's castle at Inverness

#### Summary

Macduff arrives early at the castle to wake King Duncan and discovers the murder. Macbeth and Lady Macbeth feign shock and grief, and Macbeth admits to killing the guards in his rage. King Duncan's two sons, Malcolm and Donalbain, decide to flee as they don't know who they can trust.

#### Analysis

A porter appears on the stage. He is clearly drunk and conducts an imaginary conversation, as if he were the gatekeeper to hell. This delays his ability to answer the knocking and frustrates the visitors, who continue to knock loudly. Eventually, the door is opened to Macduff and Lennox who question why he took so long to answer. The porter admits that he has been drinking and gives a comical speech about the effects of drink. Macbeth arrives, as if he has been woken by the knocking. Macduff informs him that he is here to wake Duncan, who requested to be woken early, and leaves the stage to do so. Lennox tells Macbeth about the bad weather the previous night, before Macduff returns to the stage with terrible news: Most sacrilegious murder hath broke ope The Lord's anointed temple, and stole thence The life o' th' building! (II, iii, 69–71) He confuses his friends by referring to Duncan's body as 'the Lord's anointed temple' (II, iii, 70), but this refers to the belief in the divine right of kings. During the reign of James I of England, the time this play was written, there was a general belief that kings were awarded their right to rule by God. Because of this, any attack on the king was considered to be an attack on God's will. Macduff tells his friends to see for themselves, while he wakes the rest of the castle. Lady Macbeth enters and demands to know what is going on. Macduff won't tell her because he fears that it will kill her but quickly changes his mind when Banquo arrives on the stage. Macduff's unwillingness to tell Lady Macbeth of Duncan's death highlights perceptions of women at the time as being emotionally weaker and more sensitive than men. All of the key characters return to the stage and explain to Malcolm and Donalbain what has happened. Macbeth reveals that he killed the guilty servants in a fit of rage. Macduff is immediately suspicious, asking Macbeth 'Wherefore did you so?' (II, iii, 109) but Macbeth claims that it is not possible to think logically when you are so upset. Lady Macbeth adds to the pretence of their upset by fainting. Whether this is a genuine swoon or deliberate is unclear, but it certainly works on this level. Malcolm and Donalbain quietly discuss matters and decide to leave the castle quickly, fearing that they may be in danger from their supposed friends. They are left alone on stage as the other men retire to their chambers to dress properly before meeting to solve this 'treasonous malice' (II, iii, 134). Malcolm and Donalbain decide to leave Scotland until they can decide who is to blame for their father's death. At this moment in time, they feel unable to trust anybody. Donalbain notes, 'The near in blood, / The nearer bloody' (II, iii, 142–143), meaning that their closest relatives are probably the biggest threat to them.

#### Context

Malcolm and Donalbain's fears for their lives highlight the differences between the society of Shakespeare's day and present-day society. Today we would rely on the police to find who was responsible for a murder and we would trust societal bodies to ensure that good triumphs over evil, that order is restored and that individuals are protected. Malcolm and Donalbain are forced to take things into their own hands. This scene also reveals much about the attitude towards kingship in Shakespeare's day. The horrified reaction to King Duncan's death is indicative of the status of the king at the time the play was written. In addition, Shakespeare was a particular favourite of the various monarchs that his career encompassed and so it was important that a great deal of respect was shown for kingship.

#### Debate Prompt

Do you think Lady Macbeth actually fainted? Why / why not?

## Act 2, Scene 4

### Location: Inverness – Outside Macbeth's castle

#### Summary

Ross, an old man and Macduff discuss recent events. Macduff tells Ross that the king's sons have fled, suggesting that they might be guilty of the murder, and tells him that Macbeth is about to be crowned the new king of Scotland.

#### Analysis

#### Setting

Ross enters the stage accompanied by an old man. They discuss King Duncan's murder and also the terrible weather. The old man suggests that the weather is 'unnatural, / Even like the deed that's done' (II, iv, 10–11), making a direct comparison between the weather and the unusual events. This is built upon with accounts of other bizarre and unnatural events that have taken place in the last few days. These supernatural events remind the audience of the supernatural presence that remains throughout the whole of the play. Shakespeare highlights the unnatural and grotesque nature of the king's murder by reflecting it in the unnatural weather and strange events in nature. Macduff enters the stage and they discuss Duncan's death. Macduff suggests that the king's servants were paid to commit the crime and that 'suspicion of the deed' (II, iv, 27) falls on Malcolm and Donalbain because they have mysteriously fled Scotland. The men admit that it seems a strange thing for them to do. Macduff informs the men that Macbeth has been named as the new king and is on his way to Scone to be crowned, while Duncan's body has been placed in his ancestral tomb. Macduff is on his way back to his family in Fife but Ross decides to go to the coronation in Scone. The scene ends with the three men discussing the future of Scotland. It is clear that they see Macbeth's reign as a new phase in Scottish history and one that they are worried about. Macduff says, 'Lest our old robes sit easier than our new!' (II, iv, 38), meaning that he hopes things will start to improve.

*Macbeth preparing to murder King Duncan*

#### Debate Prompts

8. Who or what do you think is responsible for the unusual events discussed in this scene?

# Debate Prompts

1. Why do you think Shakespeare uses chaos in nature to reflect chaos in the plot? Do you think it is an effective device? How would you describe the relationship between Macbeth and Macduff, at this and other points in the play?

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## Act 3, Scene 1

### Location: The Royal Palace at Forres

#### Summary

Banquo begins to have suspicions about Macbeth and Macbeth fears the prophecy that the witches gave Banquo, namely that his sons would be kings. Macbeth persuades hired assassins to agree to murder both Banquo and Fleance.

#### Analysis

Banquo enters the stage thinking about the witches' prophecies. He notes that Macbeth has now fulfilled their prophecies for him but he fears that Macbeth 'played'st most foully for 't' (III, i, 3). Banquo wonders whether the prophecy that the witches made for him will come true. Macbeth and Lady Macbeth enter as king and queen, accompanied by Lennox, Ross and various other lords and ladies. Banquo stops what he has been saying and does not share his thoughts with the others. Macbeth and his wife address Banquo as their 'chief guest' (III, i, 11) and suggest that they couldn't enjoy their celebrations without him. They invite him to a banquet that evening and query his activities for the rest of the afternoon. Banquo tells them that he will be out riding all afternoon but will return before the feast. Macbeth asks if Fleance will go with him, Banquo confirms that he will and then Banquo departs. Macbeth instructs the rest of his guests to do as they please until the banquet and they all depart, leaving Macbeth alone with one of his servants. The servant informs Macbeth that the men that they have previously discussed are waiting outside the castle. Macbeth sends the servant to bring them to him, while he ponders why he is so fearful of Banquo. He wonders whether Banquo's prophecy will come true and, if it does, bemoans the fact that 'For Banquo's issue have I filed my mind' (III, i, 64). He means that he has killed Duncan and tortured his mind, just so that Banquo's sons can be king. This angers Macbeth and he resolves to fight it. The servant returns to the stage with two murderers. It becomes apparent that Macbeth has persuaded these men that Banquo is responsible for a catalogue of wrongs done to them. Like Lady Macbeth did to him, he goads the men into thinking that letting Banquo get away with it makes them cowardly. Macbeth explains that he cannot kill their mutual foe because of his position and also because of the friends that he shares with Banquo. It is, therefore, their responsibility to kill him. The murderers agree to help Macbeth and are instructed to kill both Banquo and Fleance, when instructed, and to do it that night away from the palace. The murderers leave the stage, closely followed by Macbeth.

#### Characterisation

Significantly, although Lady Macbeth is present in the first part of this scene, she says nothing and appears to have deferred responsibility to her husband now she has achieved her goal of becoming queen. Macbeth is now making plans and taking murderous action alone, without his wife's advice or guidance. Now that he has been made king, as the witches foretold, he has become more confident and more arrogant.

#### Debate Prompts



# Debate Prompt 10

10. How is Banquo's impression of Macbeth changing? And how does his behaviour show this?

# Act 3, Scenes 2–6

11. What is Lady Macbeth's role in this scene? What do you think she is thinking or feeling at this point?

## Act 3, Scene 2

### Location: The Royal Palace at Forres

#### Summary

Macbeth and Lady Macbeth discuss their troubled minds following the murder of Duncan. They agree to put on a good show at the banquet later and Macbeth hints that he will commit a further dark deed – he does not share the details of this with Lady Macbeth, however.

#### Analysis

Lady Macbeth discusses Banquo's whereabouts with a servant. She sends the servant to summon Macbeth and begins to consider what they have done: Naught's had, all's spent, Where our desire is got without content. 'Tis safer to be that which we destroy Than by destruction dwell in doubtful joy. (III, ii, 5–8) With this speech, she seems to suggest that it is better to be murdered than to murder someone and then be so troubled by the guilt. This refers to her concern for her husband's state of mind. This concern for Macbeth shows a side to Lady Macbeth that the audience has never seen before but she remains able to take control of her emotions and urges Macbeth to do the same.

#### Theme – guilt

Macbeth appears and Lady Macbeth tells him off for being unhappy, telling him 'what's done is done' (III, ii, 13). Macbeth discusses their nightmares and emotional torment. He cannot sleep and discusses how Duncan can now sleep peacefully but he cannot. He fears that what he has gained will be taken away from him, perhaps due to his knowledge of how easily someone else could murder him, just as he murdered Duncan. The witches are still present in his mind and his language is full of reference to them and images of the dark and supernatural. Both Macbeth and Lady Macbeth appear to be upset that the murder of Duncan has not achieved their happiness; in fact it has made them unhappy. They then change the subject and begin to discuss the night ahead. They agree on the need to put on brave faces for their guests and Macbeth instructs his wife to pay particular attention to Banquo. He does not involve her in the plan to kill Banquo. She is wise enough to suspect what Macbeth has planned but he does not tell her, preferring her to 'Be innocent of the knowledge' (III, ii, 48).

#### Characterisation

Macbeth and Lady Macbeth's interaction in this scene suggests that they have a strong emotional bond. Lady Macbeth is concerned for Macbeth's emotional well-being and Macbeth tries to protect his wife's 'innocence' by not telling her about his plans for further murder. He also uses affectionate language towards her, calling her 'love', 'dear wife' and 'dearest chuck'.

#### Debate Prompt

How do you think Macbeth has changed from the start of the play? Has becoming king been a good thing for him, or not?

## Act 3, Scene 3

### Location: A field near to the royal palace

#### Summary

The murderers attack and kill Banquo, as Macbeth has instructed – but Fleance escapes.

#### Analysis

The murderers enter the stage and are joined by a third man. They wonder whether they should trust this third man but he explains that he has been sent by Macbeth. The men discuss when Banquo will come and then hear him in the distance. The audience hears Banquo shouting offstage: 'Give us a light there, ho' (III, iii, 9). It is important to remember that, once again, evil is occurring under the cover of darkness. In addition, Banquo seems to realise the dangers that could exist in the darkness. Banquo and Fleance enter the stage. Banquo makes a remark about the weather and is then attacked by the murderers. The rain is mentioned and one of the murderers says 'let it come down' (III, iii, 19), promoting the links between bad weather and evil. Banquo realises that he has been set up and urges his son to flee. Banquo is killed but Fleance escapes. The murderers realise that they have failed in part of their task but retire to the castle to tell Macbeth that Banquo has been killed.

#### Debate Prompt

Why is it significant that Fleance escaped? Can you predict the outcome of the play using this knowledge?

## Act 3, Scene 4

### Location: A banquet hall in the royal palace

#### Summary

Macbeth and Lady Macbeth welcome lords and noblemen to a banquet. Macbeth learns that Banquo has been murdered and Fleance escaped. He then sees the ghost of Banquo at his seat and reacts with fear and horror. Lady Macbeth tries to explain Macbeth's strange behaviour but eventually, as Macbeth begins shouting at the ghost, she sends their guests away.

#### Analysis

Macbeth enters the stage, which has been set up like a banquet hall. He enters with his wife and various lords and noblemen. He addresses the guests before the first murderer arrives at the door. The murderer tells Macbeth of Banquo's death, but also informs him that Fleance has escaped. Macbeth is glad that Banquo has been killed but worries about Fleance, although he notes that: ... The worm that's fled Hath nature that in time will venom breed; No teeth for'th present. (III, iv, 29–31) He means that while Fleance has the potential to pose him problems, he will not do so at the current time. Macbeth knows that he has some time to decide what to do about Fleance. The murderer exits and Lady Macbeth summons Macbeth back to the table. Just as Macbeth is invited to sit down, Banquo's ghost enters the room and sits in Macbeth's place. When Macbeth sees the ghost he reacts badly, wondering who is to blame for it. He then starts talking to the ghost. Ross suggests that Macbeth is unwell and invites the guests to leave but Lady Macbeth assures him that Macbeth is just experiencing a fit, such as he has suffered from since birth, and invites the guests to ignore Macbeth until the fit passes. Lady Macbeth assures him that there is no ghost; she tells him: 'This is the very painting of your fear' (III, iv, 61), meaning that it is a hallucination caused by his fear. Once again, she tells him to stop being a coward and to put on a brave face. Macbeth does not believe her and continues to speak to the ghost, who then vanishes. Macbeth is forced to compose himself and addresses his guests, confirming Lady Macbeth's diagnosis of his strange behaviour. Banquo's ghost reappears and returns to Macbeth's seat. On seeing it, Macbeth shouts at it and demands that it returns in any other form. He claims that he is not afraid of anything, only the form that this spirit chooses to take. When the ghost vanishes again, Macbeth addresses his guests as if they have seen it too. Lady Macbeth asks the guests to leave quickly, telling them that their questions make him worse. She is worried that Macbeth will say something incriminating. When they have all left, Macbeth discusses his plans with his wife. He wants to know why Macduff has refused to visit them, wondering if he is suspicious of Macbeth. He also plans to go to see the three witches again.

*Macbeth seeing the ghost of Banquo by Théodore Chassériau*

#### Theme – the supernatural

In this scene, Macbeth is again strongly affected by some kind of supernatural force. The influence of the witches can be felt throughout the whole play. Macbeth appeared to be goaded into killing Duncan by a vision of a floating dagger; in this scene he is forced into undignified and eccentric behaviour in public by the appearance of a ghost. Are these visions the result of Macbeth's troubled mind, or the work of the witches?

#### Debate Prompt

Which crime do you think is worse: the murder of King Duncan or the murder of Banquo? Give reasons for your answer.

## Act 3, Scene 5

### Location: A deserted heath

#### Summary

The three witches meet with their queen, Hecate. They plan another meeting with Macbeth.

#### Analysis

There is a crash of thunder and then the three witches enter the stage with Hecate. She is angry with them for their dealings with Macbeth. In particular, she is angry with them for choosing Macbeth as their target. She calls him '... a wayward son, spiteful and wrathful...' (III, v, 11–12). It is interesting that somebody as evil as Hecate still finds fault with Macbeth's behaviour. She is not happy that the witches have not included her in their dealings with Macbeth and instructs them to meet with him again. She does not specify what she will do to him, but the audience is aware that something dreadful will happen to Macbeth.

#### Language

Hecate is summoned away by singing off stage. The three witches leave the stage too, fearing her return. Once again, the witches speak in rhyming couplets, like an incantation, reinforcing their difference to the mortals in the play.

#### Debate Prompt

At this point in the play, do you think Macbeth is responsible for his own actions, or is he the victim of the witches' evil plotting? Give reasons for your answer.

## Act 3, Scene 6

### Location: Near to the Royal Palace at Forres

#### Summary

Lennox and another Scottish lord discuss what has happened in Scotland: Macduff has fled to England where he is joining forces with the English King and Duncan's son, Malcolm. War looks likely. Lennox hopes that Scotland will soon be rescued from the tyrannical rule of Macbeth.

#### Analysis

Lennox enters the stage with another lord and they discuss the events of the play, allowing the audience to hear how Macbeth's actions are being perceived beyond the castle. We learn that the murder of Banquo has been blamed on Fleance because he has now fled Scotland. Lennox's words appear to be in support of Macbeth's handling of the murders of Banquo and Duncan but it is unclear whether there is disbelief in what he says: 'Was not that nobly done? Ay, and wisely too' (III, vi, 14). He suggests that Macbeth had to kill the guards because people could not bear to hear them deny what they had done. His staunch and perhaps excessive defence of Macbeth could be seen as a subtle way of expressing his concerns. The lord informs Lennox that Malcolm is with the king of England and that Macduff has gone there too, to request the king of England's help in a battle against Macbeth. Macbeth has heard the news of Macduff's plans and is preparing for war. Macbeth has summoned Macduff to Scotland but Macduff refused to go. Lennox tells the lord that he hopes Macduff returns to free Scotland sooner rather than later. He refers to Macbeth as a 'tyrant'.

#### Context

This scene shows how Macbeth's society has descended into suspicion and confusion – this is something that present-day audiences can easily identify with. When something bad has happened and the culprit is unknown, it is impossible to know who is trustworthy and who is not. It is easy to attach blame to the wrong person or people and this is a feature common in contemporary news stories, television and cinema.

# Act 4, Scenes 1–3

## Act 4, Scene 1

### Location: A cavern in a deserted place

#### Summary

Macbeth meets with the three witches and their queen, Hecate. The witches show Macbeth three apparitions as clues to what the future holds. Macbeth is comforted by some of these, and alarmed by others.

#### Analysis

#### Setting

Thunder strikes and the three witches enter the stage, which has been set up to look like a cavern. There is a boiling cauldron in the centre of the stage. Again, the setting of the scene highlights the evil intentions of the witches. This is one of the most famous and powerful scenes of the play and centres around the three witches casting a spell for Macbeth. The fantastical ingredients put into the cauldron are sickening and grotesque, like the witches themselves, who Macbeth has chosen as advisors. The most powerful of all evil spirits, Hecate, is there to oversee the arrival of Macbeth. She arrives with three other witches and together they sing a song. Macbeth's presence is foretold by the couplet: By the pricking of my thumbs, Something wicked this way comes. (IV, i, 59–60)

#### Characterisation

It is interesting to note that Macbeth is not referred to by his name but as a 'wicked thing'. Macbeth has become as wicked and evil as the witches but he is oblivious to his demise. He is so deluded and self-obsessed that he seems to believe he is important enough to command the respect of the witches, even though his greeting implies he has no respect for them. Macbeth demands answers from the witches, who offer him the chance to get answers from their masters. This plays to Macbeth's arrogance, making him feel worthy of dealing with the most important people. The first of three apparitions appears; it is an armed head and Macbeth is warned to beware Macduff. This merely confirms his previous instinct. Macbeth commands that the apparition stays but it leaves.

First apparition: an armed head

The warning given by the next apparition, a bloody child, is that Macbeth need not fear anyone born of a woman. This puts Macbeth's mind at rest a little but he resolves to kill Macduff anyway, just to settle himself. The third apparition is a crowned child, carrying a tree. It tells him that he will not be defeated 'until Great Birnam Wood to high Dunsinane Hill / Shall come against him' (IV, i, 107–108). Macbeth takes this cryptic message as a confirmation of his own invulnerability but still he demands to know the answer to the question that is burning in his mind: will Banquo's children become kings? The witches tell Macbeth 'Seek to know no more!' (IV, i, 118) but he is insistent and even curses them for denying him this knowledge. It is strange that Macbeth thinks that he could curse these already cursed creatures. When Macbeth's wishes are met, eight kings walk across the stage followed by the ghost of Banquo. Macbeth is furious, he turns on the witches because they didn't give him the answers he wanted to hear but this makes little impression on them and they simply vanish, refusing to meet any more of his demands. This provokes him to exclaim 'damn'd be all that trust them' (IV, i, 155). This is very poignant because Macbeth does not listen to his own advice, so blinded is he to what he has become.

#### Context

The witches fail to give Macbeth the answers that he is looking for and he loses his temper with them. He seems to believe that he has the power to order them to do things and this provides us with a reminder of the social order in Shakespeare's day. It should also provide contemporary audiences with food for thought. Should groups or individuals that exist outside of mainstream society be expected to follow accepted codes of behaviour? By this point, Lennox has entered the stage with news that Macduff has fled to England. Macbeth is annoyed that he did not kill Macduff as soon as he thought of it but decides to have his family and servants killed as soon as possible. Now we can see (if we hadn't noticed before) that Macbeth has no restraint or forethought for the consequences of his actions. He does not care if he is a good king; simply that he is king.

#### Debate Prompt

Macbeth mistakenly believes that he can control the witches. Can you find other examples of people/events that Macbeth mistakenly believes he is in control of?

Second apparition: a bloody child. Third apparition: a crowned child.

## Act 4, Scene 2

### Location: Macduff's castle at Fife

#### Summary

Lady Macduff fears for her safety and asks Ross why her husband has left her alone with the children. Soon after Ross leaves, murderers arrive and brutally murder Lady Macduff's son. The scene ends as Lady Macduff runs for her life.

#### Analysis

This scene opens with Lady Macduff and her son in deep discussion with Ross. Lady Macduff is annoyed that Macduff has fled to England, leaving her and her son alone. Ross tries to defend him but she will not accept that it was wise for him to leave. If he feared for his safety, surely they are in danger too? Ross tries to reassure Lady Macduff but suggests that she leaves the castle. He then leaves the stage. Lady Macduff observes that 'Our fears do make us traitors' (IV, ii, 4), because they are no more trusting, loyal subjects of their king, instead they are afraid of him and fear his unpredictable behaviour. Lady Macduff tells her son that his father is dead but he does not believe her, as she is not weeping. Her son asks various questions about treachery and crimes before coming to the conclusion that 'there are liars and swearers enough to beat the honest men and hang up them' (IV, ii, 58–59). Just then a messenger appears informing Lady Macduff that she and her son are in danger. The messenger leaves and Lady Macduff wonders why she should leave when she has done nothing wrong. She realises that with the current state of the country, being innocent is not necessarily enough, but it is too late... the murderers enter the room. The murderers ask where Macduff is and both Lady Macduff and her son are rude to them. Macduff's son is killed and Lady Macduff exits the stage, followed by the murderers.

#### Context

Lady Macduff's presence in the play reminds the audience of the more socially acceptable female character. She is helpless and powerless. She has no control over her fate, no control over her husband's actions and makes no attempt to save herself from death. It is interesting to see how the behaviour of this ideal female character is altered in more modern adaptations of the play, in order to fit with the conventions of the day.

#### Characterisation

The slaughter of Macduff's innocent family is a new low in Macbeth's violent behaviour. It demonstrates just how brutal Macbeth has become and suggests that he is out of control. He is acting out of anger and desperation with no rational thought or consideration for consequences.

#### Debate Prompt

This scene provides a domestic viewpoint on the action of the play. Why do you think Shakespeare has added this scene at this point in the play?

## Act 4, Scene 3

### Location: The royal palace in England

#### Summary

Macduff and King Duncan's son, Malcolm, meet at the English court. They test each other's loyalties and when they finally agree to trust each other they discuss a joint attack against Macbeth who, they feel, is destroying Scotland. Macduff hears from Ross the terrible news that his wife and children have been brutally murdered and he vows to avenge their deaths.

#### Analysis

Malcolm and Macduff enter the stage. The audience have just witnessed the murder of Macduff's family but he is not yet aware of it. The men discuss the situation in Scotland in the most unflattering terms: 'It weeps, it bleeds, and each new day a gash / Is added to her wounds' (IV, iii, 40–41). The two men feel that Macbeth's tyranny is ravaging Scotland and they do not know what to do about it. It is clear that the two men do not know whether to trust each other. The dishonesty Macbeth has used to gain power has created an atmosphere of fear where nobody is able to trust another, so Malcolm feels the need to test Macduff's loyalty before he can accept him as a follower. He pretends to be a man as unfit to rule Scotland as Macbeth himself: lustful, greedy and jealous. Only when Macduff expresses his horror and regret that the son of such a good king and queen as Duncan and his wife should not be a more worthy candidate for leadership, does Malcolm reveal his true feelings and his plans to fight Macbeth. Both have been honest and good men in the past but both men are usually loyal to the king. Malcolm points out that 'A good and virtuous nature may recoil / In an imperial charge' (IV, iii, 19–20). By this he means that honest men do dishonourable things because they have been ordered to by their king. How can he trust that Macduff is not working for Macbeth? Eventually, the men agree to trust each other and fight together against the tyrant, Macbeth.

#### Context

When Malcolm and Macduff meet to discuss the fate of Scotland under its new king, the audience are reminded of the differences between Shakespeare's society and their own. The men go to great lengths to stress their allegiances to Scotland, before they begin to plan Macbeth's downfall. They insist that they are usually loyal to the king but cannot stand by and let Macbeth destroy their country. Such patriotism and respect for the monarchy would be much less valued in today's society, but in Shakespeare's day it was very important. This exchange would have been particularly appealing to King James. Ross enters the stage and Macduff enquires about the fate of his family. Ross tells him that they were 'at peace' (IV, iii, 179) when he left them but eventually admits that he has since heard news that the castle has been attacked and Macduff's family have been slaughtered. Malcolm, perhaps insensitively, suggests that Macduff deals with the grief by taking revenge: 'Let's make us med'cines of our great revenge, / To cure this deadly grief' (IV, iii, 214–215). He suggests that avenging their deaths and taking back Scotland will be the best cure for Macduff's grief and they leave the stage to meet with King Edward of England and plan their attack.

#### Debate Prompt

Do you think Malcolm would make a good king? Why, or why not?

# Act 5, Scene 1

**Location: A room in Dunsinane Castle**

## Summary

A doctor has been called to attend to Lady Macbeth, who has started to walk in her sleep and speak strangely of her nightmares.

## Analysis

The scene opens with a gentlewoman and a doctor, who are discussing the condition of Lady Macbeth. We learn that 'since his majesty went into the field' (V, i, 4) Lady Macbeth has been sleepwalking and talking in her sleep about things that the gentlewoman could not repeat. As they continue to discuss it, Lady Macbeth enters the room. Lady Macbeth re-enacts conversations that she had with her husband on the nights of Duncan and Banquo's murders. These are overheard by the doctor and the gentlewoman: Out, damned spot! out, I say! One – two – why, then 'tis time to do 't.



# Act 5, Scene 1 (continued)

- Hell is murky! - Fie, my lord, fie, a soldier, and afeard? What need we fear who knows it, when none can call our power to account?— Yet who would have thought the old man to have had so much blood in him? [...] The thane of Fife had a wife - where is she now? What, will these hands ne'er be clean?—No more o' that, my lord, no more o' that; you mar all with this starting (V, i, 23–33)

She repeats the statement she made to Macbeth earlier, that: 'what's done cannot be undone' (V, i, 65), but now this has a hollow ring to it as we have seen the effect it has had on the lives of everyone involved. Where it previously appeared to suggest that they should carry on with their lives as normal, it now seems to suggest that they can never be normal again. The doctor explains that 'Unnatural deeds / Do breed unnatural troubles' (V, i, 69–70), meaning that Lady Macbeth's strange behaviour has been caused by something unnatural. In Shakespeare's time, sleepwalking was considered a highly abnormal activity. The doctor suggests that he cannot help her and that Lady Macbeth needs a priest to unburden her mind: 'More needs the divine than the physician' (V, i, 72). He recommends that the gentlewoman keep a close eye on Lady Macbeth and remove anything that she might use to cause herself harm.

## Characterisation

Lady Macbeth has been absent from the action of the play for some time. The audience can see a clear degeneration in her state of mind, especially by her compulsion to wash her hands, and a clear change in her role in her marriage as well as in the play. It is interesting to note that the doctor and gentlewoman speak in prose, rather than the formal speech of the nobility, and that Lady Macbeth does the same.

## Debate Prompts

1. In what ways could you argue that Macbeth and Lady Macbeth have swapped roles in the play?



# Act 5, Scenes 2–8

2. What do you think will happen to Lady Macbeth?

## Act 5, Scene 2

**Location: The countryside somewhere near Dunsinane castle**

### Summary

Soldiers march towards Dunsinane, preparing for battle against Macbeth.

### Analysis

Mentieth, Caithness, Angus and Lennox enter the stage, alongside soldiers carrying flags. They discuss the imminent arrival of Malcolm. It is now common knowledge that Macbeth was responsible for the various murders that have taken place: 'Now does he feel / His secret murders sticking on his hands' (V, ii, 16–17). This quotation is particularly relevant because the image of having blood on one's hands is one that is used by both Macbeth and Lady Macbeth earlier in the play. Malcolm and Macduff have brought an army from England and are aided by Malcolm's English uncle, Siward. Menteith remarks: Revenges burn in them, for their dear causes Would to the bleeding and the grim alarm Excite the mortified man. (V, ii, 3–5) He means that the men are desperate for revenge and that the wrongs that have been done to them would be enough to raise the dead back to life, in order to wreak revenge. Interestingly, the men note that Donalbain is not with his brother. They discuss the fact that Macbeth is fortifying his castle and question his state of mind. They all agree that he is out of control. It is interesting to see that not all of Scotland has turned against Macbeth. Macbeth still has followers, but they 'move only in command / Nothing in love' (V, ii, 19–20). He is hanging on to his kingship by a thread, with only his belief in the witches' prophecies to keep him feeling confident in his victory.

### Structure

This scene, and the scenes that follow, are very short. The sudden changes of setting and character and the fast-paced action all build tension and add to the sense that events are moving quickly and building towards a final climax.

### Debate Prompt

Are there any points in this scene when the audience may realise what is going to happen? (Particularly in relation to the witches' prophecies.)

## Act 5, Scene 3

**Location: A room in the castle at Dunsinane**

### Summary

Macbeth hears that a huge army is approaching the castle. He talks to the doctor about Lady Macbeth's illness and then he prepares himself for the battle that lies ahead.

### Analysis

Macbeth is on stage, accompanied by a doctor, attendants and a servant. He knows of the incoming attack but insists that he has nothing to fear because of what he has learned from the witches' prophecies. Macbeth's men clearly do not know what he is talking about and hence Macbeth is a very isolated character in this scene. His men seem to fear him and the unfortunate servant who has to give him the news that an army of 10,000 men has gathered to fight him wears a 'goose look' (V, iii, 12): in other words he is obviously terrified. Macbeth puts on his armour and says: 'I'll fight till from my bones my flesh be hacked' (V, iii, 31) – he will fight until there is no flesh left on his body. Macbeth asks the doctor about his wife's health. The doctor advises him that she is not ill, merely troubled by images that are stopping her from sleeping. Macbeth's reaction is bizarre: Cure her of that. Canst thou not minister to a mind diseased, Pluck from the memory a rooted sorrow, Raze out the written troubles of the brain And with some sweet oblivious antidote Cleanse the stuffed bosom of that perilous stuff Which weighs upon the heart? (V, iii, 38–44) Macbeth does not accept what the doctor tells him. As we can see from the quotation above, Macbeth demands that the doctor find her a cure. Macbeth seems to believe that he even has the power to control science! Macbeth does nothing to help his wife. Instead, he puts on his armour and prepares to lead his men into battle with Malcolm. The men are clearly terrified.

### Debate Prompt

Why do you think Macbeth continues to believe in what the witches have told him, even now when his situation appears to be quite desperate?

## Act 5, Scene 4

**Location: In the countryside near to Birnam Wood**

### Summary

Malcolm's soldiers decide to use branches cut from the trees of Birnam Wood to camouflage themselves as they approach Dunsinane castle.

### Analysis

The key figures in the fight against Macbeth appear on stage. We learn that they are at Birnam Wood. Malcolm gives the following order to his men: 'Let every soldier hew him down a bough / And bear 't before him' (V, iv, 4–5). He means that all of his men should take branches from the trees and use them to conceal themselves from Macbeth. In this way, Macbeth's spies will have no idea how many of them are there and ready to attack him.

### Debate Prompt

What is the significance of Malcolm's order to cut down the branches? What do you think will happen next?

## Act 5, Scene 5

**Location: Inside the castle at Dunsinane**

### Summary

Lady Macbeth commits suicide and Macbeth is told that Birnam Wood is approaching Dunsinane.

### Analysis

Macbeth instructs his men to decorate the castle with flags. He says that he would have been able to meet the attacking forces outside of the castle, if so many of his men had not turned against him. He still does not realise that the revolt of so many men might be an indicator that he is in the wrong! They hear the sound of a woman crying and Macbeth remarks that it is not easy to scare him now that he has experienced so many horrors: 'I have supp'd full of horrors / Direness, familiar to my slaughterous thoughts, / Cannot once start me' (V, v, 13–15). We learn that the cry was Lady Macbeth committing suicide.

### Characterisation

Lady Macbeth's death inspires Macbeth to make a long speech. He seems to have developed a very philosophical approach to life and death. It seems that he is no longer afraid or interested in the difference between life and death. Having experienced the power of having somebody's life in his hands, Macbeth seems to have concluded that life is meaningless: 'Life is but a walking shadow [...] signifying nothing' (V, v, 24–28). Macbeth might also be expressing his feeling that life without his wife is meaningless – what, after all, has all this murdering been for? Macbeth has very little left to fight for, aside from the conviction that this battle is preordained. However, at this critical moment, he receives a message that Birnam Wood is advancing towards the castle. This is the last thing Macbeth wants to hear and it is greeted with threats and remonstrations from him, although they amount to little as there is a definite sense that Macbeth's time has come.

### Debate Prompts

# Act 5, Scenes 6–8

1. What is the effect of Lady Macbeth's suicide? Why do you think Macbeth continues his preparations for battle, despite Lady Macbeth's death? Macbeth seems to claim that he is now fearless. To what extent do you agree?

## Act 5, Scene 6

### Location: In front of the castle at Dunsinane

#### Summary

The attacking army arrives at Dunsinane and the soldiers throw aside their branches, ready to fight.

#### Analysis

The attacking forces are instructed to throw down the branches and reveal themselves to Macbeth: 'Your leafy screens thrown down / And show like those you are' (V, vi, 1–2). This is done to surprise Macbeth with the extent of the oncoming attack. Macbeth did not predict the size of Malcolm's army. It is decided that Siward and his son will lead the first attack and that Malcolm and Macduff will follow. Trumpets are sounded to announce their attack. This short scene brings us to the climax of the play and Macbeth's ultimate demise. Siward's words as he goes into battle provide insight into true bravery and ambition: 'Let us be beaten if we cannot fight' (V, vi, 8). Here, he cements an idea put forward earlier by Banquo, the idea that he will take the fate that he deserves. If he earns victory, he will take its spoils. If he does not, he wishes to be defeated.

## Act 5, Scene 7

### Location: Somewhere on the battlefield

#### Summary

The battle is raging. Macbeth kills Young Siward. Macduff vows to kill only Macbeth.

#### Analysis

Macbeth knows that his first fight is imminent and he clings on to the witches' prophecy that no man born of a woman can hurt him. It is strange that Macbeth continues to believe in the witches when their earlier prophecy has just been exposed as a clever trick. Young Siward enters Macbeth's room and, after a short exchange, Macbeth kills him and then exits the stage. Macduff enters and is clearly looking for Macbeth and only Macbeth. He is a mightier adversary and Macbeth has been warned to be afraid of him. Macduff says: 'Either thou, Macbeth, / Or else my sword with an unbattered edge / I sheathe again undeeded' (V, vii, 19–21). He will fight Macbeth and, if he is not able to find him, he will put away his sword unused. Macduff does not want to find Macbeth's men who have been coerced or paid to fight for him. He leaves the stage. Malcolm and Siward enter and give the report that the castle has already been surrendered and that some of Macbeth's men have changed sides. The battle is almost over. They exit the stage, as if entering the castle.

#### Debate Prompt

Why do you think Macbeth clings on to the witches' prophecy about 'no man of a woman born' (IV, i, 80)?

## Act 5, Scene 8

In some versions of the play, Scenes 7 and 8 are together in one scene

### Location: Somewhere on the battlefield

#### Summary

In the final scene of the play, Macduff confronts Macbeth and eventually kills him. He brings Macbeth's head to Malcolm and his soldiers and he declares Malcolm to be the new king of Scotland.

#### Analysis

Macbeth's opening lines seem to suggest that he knows that he has no hope of success now: Why should I play the Roman fool and die On mine own sword? Whiles I see lives, the gashes Do better upon them. (V, vii, 31–33) He explains that he will not commit suicide because while any of his enemies are still alive, his sword is better used to attack them. Macduff arrives and Macbeth admits that Macduff is the only man that he fears. Nonetheless, he tells Macduff that there is no point fighting because Macduff will not be able to harm him, citing the witches' prophecy as his evidence. Macduff dramatically reveals that he was not born of a woman and finally the audience can make sense of everything! Macbeth finally realises that the witches have tricked him, and he refuses to fight Macduff. Macduff taunts him with thoughts of what they would do with a tyrant such as Macbeth, who decided to surrender. It seems that Macduff does not want him to surrender. Macbeth is roused to fight again and remarks: 'I will try to last' (V, vii, 62) – he will fight to the end. The two men begin to fight and exit the stage fighting. They return to the stage, still fighting, and Macbeth is killed. Malcolm, Ross, Siward and various other thanes enter the stage. They discuss the missing men and wish that all had survived to see their victory. Siward is informed that his son has been killed. His reaction to the death is strange – he does not seem to feel sorrow but instead is comforted by the way in which his son died, fighting bravely. Macduff enters, carrying Macbeth's head; he hails Malcolm King of Scotland. In celebration, Malcolm names all of his thanes as earls, noting that Scotland has never had earls before. He invites them all to his coronation.

#### Debate Prompts

1. Why do you think Macduff goads Macbeth into fighting for his life? Do you think that Macbeth was ultimately the victim of the witches'